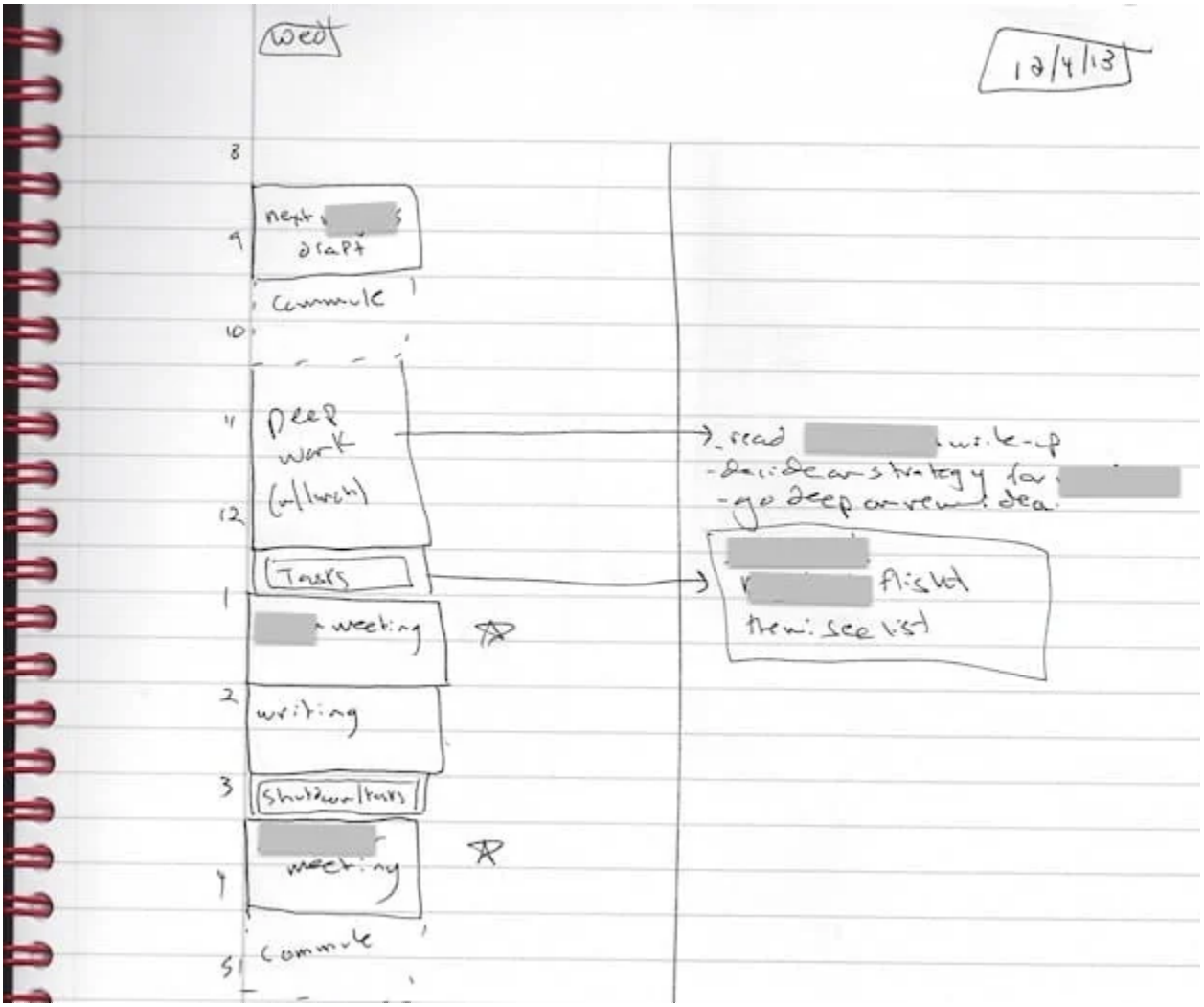
CAL NEWPORT

Deep Habits: The Importance of Planning Every Minute of Your Work Day

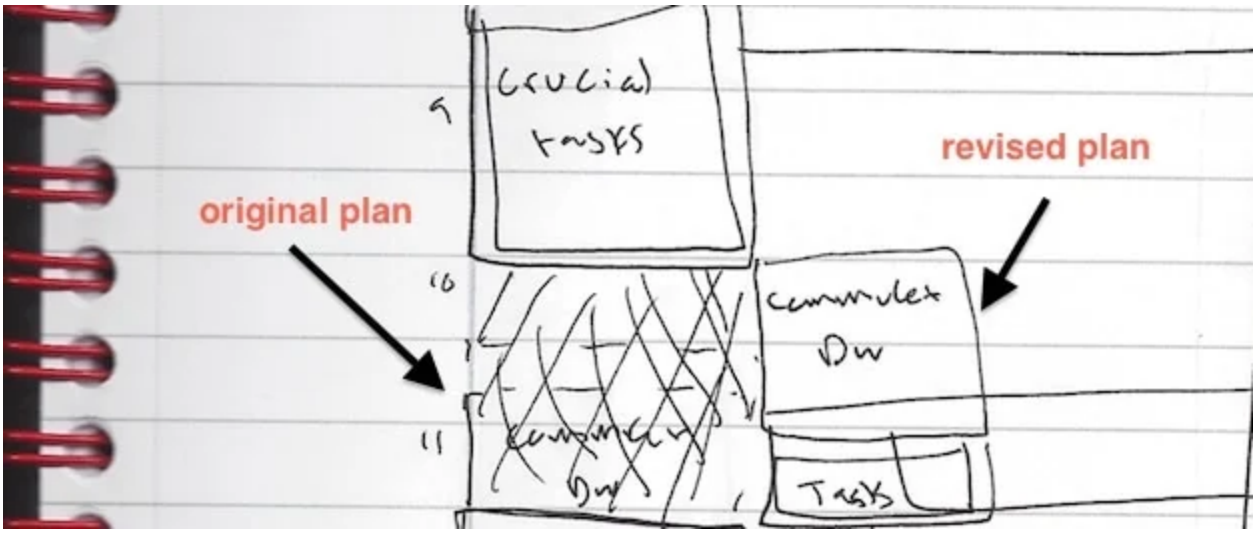
December 21, 2013



Time Blocking

month. My plan was captured on a single sheet of 24 pound paper in a Black n' Red twin wire notebook. This page is divided into two columns. In the left column, I dedicated two lines to each hour of the day and then divided that time into blocks labeled with specific assignments. In the right column, I add explanatory notes for these blocks where needed.

Notice that I leave some extra room next to my time blocks. This allows me to make corrections as needed if the day unfolds in an unexpected way:



I call this planning method *time blocking*. I take time blocking seriously, dedicating ten to twenty minutes every evening to building my schedule for the next day. During this planning process I consult my task lists and calendars, as well as my weekly and quarterly planning notes. My goal is to make sure progress is being made on the right things at the right pace for the relevant deadlines.

This type of planning, to me, is like a chess game, with blocks of work getting spread and sorted in such a way that projects big and small all seem to click into completion with (just enough) time to spare.

Three Concerns

Sometimes people ask why I bother with such a detailed level of

productivity. A 40 hour time-blocked work week, I estimate, produces the same amount of output as a 60+ hour work week pursued without structure.

Sometimes people ask how time blocking can work for reactive work, where you cannot tell in advance what obligations will enter your life on a given day. My answer is again simple: **periods of open-ended reactivity can be blocked off like any other type of obligation.** Even if you're blocking *most* of your day for reactive work, for example, the fact that you are controlling your schedule will allow you to dedicate some small blocks (perhaps at the schedule periphery) to deeper pursuits.

(Another smart strategy in this context is to give open-ended reactive blocks secondary purposes: e.g., "process client requests; if I have downtime during this block, work on project X.")

Sometimes people ask if controlling time will stifle creativity. I understand this concern, but it's fundamentally misguided. If you control your schedule: (1) **you can ensure that you consistently dedicate time to the deep efforts that matter for creative pursuits**; and (2) **the stress relief that comes from this sense of organization allows you to go deeper in your creative blocks** and produce more value.

If you're still worried, read Mason Currey's *Daily Rituals*: very few of the world-famous creatives he profiled adopted a "I'll work when I feel inspired" attitude — they instead controlled their day so they could control their art.

Conclusion

In the context of work, uncontrolled time makes me uncomfortable. If you're serious about working deeply and producing high-end value, it should probably make you uncomfortable as well. Using your inbox to drive your daily schedule might be fine for the entry-level or those content with a career of cubicle-dwelling mediocrity, but the best

capital, as a resource to wield for maximum returns.

‹ The Difficulties of Depth: A Case Study in Getting Important Things Done

› 37 Signal's Formula for a Satisfying Career (Hint: It's Not Passion)

272 thoughts on "Deep Habits: The Importance of Planning Every Minute of Your Work Day"



Bob Tabor

December 21, 2013 at 3:39 pm

I've bought into this idea. However, I can't get it to work … I know it's me. I'm so bad at estimating how long things will take or I run into technical issues that throws the schedule completely off. Suggestions?

Reply



Claire

December 21, 2013 at 4:03 pm

I think the biggest key to time blocking is actually just that, being honest with yourself and knowing how long it will actually take you to do things and planning with that in mind. It takes a while to learn, so what I would suggest is definitely overestimating the amount of time it will take you to do things. When I first started

block of time — but still do your best to treat it like you don't have that half hour. It's great because if you manage to make the time you initially thought, you have extra time, and if you do need that extra time you've planned accordingly for it. Also be sure to note down how much time you actually took and how far from your estimate you were for next time. Then you keep tweaking the schedule until you've figured out how much time everything actually takes.

Reply

Niko

December 22, 2013 at 7:38 pm

When I first started experimenting with time management systems, I tried a very strict scheduling system. This was an unmitigated disaster which failed completely and derailed me for a long time.

Since then I have found help with other systems, but just recently have come to somewhat similar system as Cal. His system has one fundamental difference to my original failed system: the content is not strictly defined.

One important truth is you cannot fix content and schedule at the same time. It's just human nature we are so poor at predicting how long something will take. Scheduling a day with a sequence of very detailed actions is going to fail. You have to choose which you are going to keep up with: the schedule or the content.

get done during the time block, but you have to leave a lot of flexibility to the content.

Reply

Bob Tabor

December 25, 2013 at 5:39 pm

Thank you both. @Niko, I am in the content business too, and I think you've hit the nail on the head with regards to CHOOSING either / or. Sure, I have REALIZED that this was the case (unknown unknowns with creating content leading to the impossibility to schedule) but I've not taken the next logical step like you did ... to admit it and let the choice drive you. My immediate reaction is that I will schedule the NEXT time block or maybe two, but when the path ahead is murky planning ten steps ahead is pointless and probably counterproductive. Thank you.

Reply

Justin

August 19, 2015 at 11:08 pm

I'm a little late to the party but I've found giving myself an extra 15 to 30 minutes for every hour that I think I need helps out a ton. Once you get good at it you probably won't need the "buffer time."

Reply

Rafim

September 12, 2018 at 6:37 am

You can use a time tracker app called "Toggle".Use this app for a week,research how much time it took to finish the specific task you're trying to do for each of the 7 days. Then average the time.That's how you can know how much time do you need for specific tasks.

Reply

Phillip Choi

July 15, 2019 at 4:48 pm

Regarding estimation, human beings regularly underestimate time requirements for the overall task compared to their sum of estimates for the sub-components of the overall task. The simple solution is to break up the task into sub-tasks, and then block in your sub tasks.

Reply

Mark
December 21, 2013 at 4:14 pm

Thank you so much for sharing this information and pictures. They help a lot in order to understand your way of blocking.

You said you work 40 hours per week. I was wondering if that was the amount of time you worked while you were a graduate student.

Thanks a lot,
Mark

Reply

Mark
December 21, 2013 at 7:14 pm

I just read daily rituals. Interesting. Better for a day at the library than a buy since it goes so fast.

I got into this during medical school using a calendar app. I realized that I needed at least two hours of study per hour of lecture to grasp material. So I blocked those off at the beginning of

A block is 20 mins work, 5 break 20 work 15 min break. Also, figure travel time and time to set up and organize to get into the work zone.

I would have big 4 hour blocks where I'd get 3 hours of solid work done, but there'd be a lot of time off.

Other students would block off every second and expect to work it all. They wouldn't. They'd burn out. They lived their life lying to themselves, which seemed to get about the same work done in a more stressful way.

Reply

biwabiwa
July 23, 2015 at 6:27 am

Hi Mark,

Would you mind sharing what calendar app you used while in medical school?

Thank you!

Reply

Mike Lindgren
September 3, 2015 at 2:17 pm

As a non-traditional student i'm just starting college at 35. I am very interested from learning from all the pre-health students here who have a lot to balance in order to get into medical school. What works and what doesn't.

Reply

Kendra Patterson
October 11, 2016 at 7:03 pm

have you heard of cram fighter ? When you say calendar app is this what you are referring to? Cram fighter schedules a study plan based on time blocking.

Reply

Pontriyagin

December 21, 2013 at 7:36 pm

There are several very different tasks that are being targeted within one day. I typically find that having too many of these is hard. The reason is that each of these has a "start-up" cost: it takes 45 minutes just to get into the flow of things and then you stop half an hour later and move to something else?

Reply

Rob

December 21, 2013 at 8:15 pm

Structures time is what you must do to increase creativity.

See https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=AU5x1Ea7NjQ

Reply

Evan

December 22, 2013 at 4:37 am

This article stresses something that confused me about your book, HTBAHSS. One of the main ideas seems to be to allow large blocks of free time in your schedule which will allow you to increase

unstructured by nature, so I found it hard to turn down other pursuits (e.g. social) and stay focused on, say, a programming project. Perhaps time blocking certain weeknights would help high school students, or maybe I missed what you were trying to convey.

Reply

Pete

December 23, 2013 at 8:22 pm

Cal's workday seems to end about 6:30, which leaves the rest of the evening for individual pursuits & projects. This means that when high school is out for the day you go right into homework mode instead of hanging with friends or playing video games, etc.
Not being as smart as Cal, my own workday ends about 8ish. If I don't have a project to work on, I'll work on a hobby or do some non-brain work such as making study flash-cards or do the first reading of a novel for school. (I always do two readings: the first is straight through as pseudo enjoyment, the second is where I take notes.) The last thing I do before brain-quiet time is to go over my assignments calendar and flesh out tomorrow's do list.
Planning structure for the do-list is not that hard as math is always the two hours right after school and so on
No school work is done on Saturday, Friday after supper (more or less), or Sunday morning. This leaves enough time for socializing.
No socializing on school nights
Once I stopped watching television, I had more time than I knew what to do with

Reply

Maruan
December 22, 2013 at 10:36 am

Thanks for sharing, Cal.

I came across your blog very recently, and I enjoy reading and learning from each of your posts.

Regarding the tracking, have you tried doing sort of A/B testing of

time tracking equals 60+ hours without. Is it based on the tests you have done? If yes, for how long did you do them? Have you tried alternating time tracking with periods of no-tracking?

I am asking since I was kind of obsessed with tracking my time back a couple of years ago. I gave up doing so after 6 months. That time, the reason was the unpredictability of my deadline-based and event-based schedule. It happened that sometimes when you intentionally break your plans, forget about tracking, and go and do something that just popped up as good opportunity for right now, it might make you even more effective. I tried different things, but I realized that I was spending too much time (at least 30 minutes everyday and 30-40 by the end of each week) on keeping track of every minute and making plans that don't work or work not that good as I expected.

Thanks,
Maruan

Reply

Swaroop C H

December 22, 2013 at 2:47 pm

Pomodoro technique's daily sheet is a simple way of achieving this kind of daily time blocking 🙂

Reply

Wan Muhammad Zulfikri

December 22, 2013 at 3:48 pm

Thanks for the post Cal.

I'm glad I found this blog of yours because the contents are really valuable especially for someone going to medical school.

I really need to plan my time well and your methods make the most sense.

Reply

Carl Newmeyer

December 22, 2013 at 8:45 pm

Cal, first I want to say that your “So Good” book has changed my work life and added thousands to my bottom line since reading it six months ago–and my work life feels great to boot. So let me know where to send the royalties.

And you wrote something interesting: “In the context of work, uncontrolled time makes me uncomfortable……probably make you uncomfortable as well.”

I don’t advocate completely uncontrolled time. Yet I would ask–is it possible that complete avoidance of uncontrolled time equates to some fear of the unknown–as there’s a great deal of mystery to our existence–I think it healthy to let go into that mystery. Didn’t even Einstein have a perspective about this?

Reply

Yuanzhi

December 23, 2013 at 12:19 am

Thanks for your tips for improving working productivity. I’ve leant a lot from your post.
I’m a PhD student in China facing my final paper and thesis writing. They’re such a huge task for me. I’m trying to adopt your suggestion to my work and hopefully I can achieve a better result in no long future. Wish you a merry Christmas and happy new year..
Please keep on writing things like this, that help me a lot!!

Best wishes!

Dave Small

December 23, 2013 at 1:44 am

Thanks for the information Cal. For those struggling with scheduling and “time blocking”, I suggest starting with at least one hour of focus per day. Even this is difficult for a lot of people — yet something that simple can begin to change the course of a person’s life/career.

Reply

David Drake

December 23, 2013 at 5:45 pm

I am currently using GTD as my primary time management approach although recently I have adapted many of the ideas from Len Merson's instant productivity toolkit. I am a professor of microbiology & infectious diseases and have many responsibilities at my college, university, and nationally. I do think I need more structure in my day as the hard, focused work gets pushed to the side all too often with so many "busy" tasks that come my way. So... what does everyone think of GTD and the instant productivity toolkit approaches? Is one better for integrating with time blocking as described by Cal?

Reply

Ondrej

December 24, 2013 at 7:23 am

These days I use very simple app called Sooner or Later. (Windows Phone, Things for iOS would work too). I have blocks of time that cover 90 percent of my needs: daily 1h fitness block with planned lifting, walking and a reminder of what is the food I should base my diet on, Social 2h block that includes girls, friends and family and 4h Development block for studying and other skills- car driving, financial intelligence, other interests in systems not directly work related. This is 7h a day, on top of my scheduled university lectures. It works, but I may have to block even less during busy days and could block more during free days. I believe people crave 3 things: connection with the wild, with people and with mystery. I accomplish these daily. The Social block helps to avoid compliance – you see people, need to collaborate etc. Value building habits that isolate you are dangerous. The app I use automatically lists these "to-dos" in a very simple manner and I tick

quickly add specific tasks for the day, like watching football or sending specific email, but most of it is kind of pre-planned. These apps are kind of scary because there is no way to play with detailed plans. You either work or you don't.

Reply

Ondrej

December 24, 2013 at 7:29 am

Social block helps to bring compliance to your life…"ask yourself are you a capitalist or socialist in your personal life? Are you seeking to avoid the marketplace, head in the sand? Just count off the activites that fill your week. How many of them require you to enlist the freely-given cooperation of others or for your team to best another team in honest competition. Examples of compliance / capitalism in action….
Going out drinking with a bunch of friends
A road trip with buddies
Dating a hot girl
Sparring at your boxing / BJJ class
Winning an argument
Having your work colleagues ask you to lead a project
Many activities which are good for your self-development and good for life-enrichment are also non-compliance / socialist activities.
Reading / studying
Writing a blog
Travelling solo or always with the same friend
Being disciplined about your nutrition
Hitting the gym
Be careful with them. Its good to have a few but if you find you are always staying home to "work on my philosophy" rather than

weaseled yourself. Seek the feedback....."

Reply

Julian M

January 1, 2020 at 5:18 am

Hey ONDREJ, I was wondering what you mean by "How many of them require you to enlist the freely-given cooperation of others or for your team to best another team in honest competition." Are you speaking of activities that benefit others but don't benefit you, a mix of both, or activities that DON'T go to your deeper pursuit of life such as, for example, building a company, or practicing to be the best basketball player?

Reply

Laura

December 24, 2013 at 10:57 pm

How do you keep track of your work from day to day? Other than keeping a tally of hours of deep work, do you keep a more specific record i.e some kind of work/research journal?

Thanks for the article, have a good Christmas,
Laura

Reply

A

December 25, 2013 at 4:55 am

"my weekly and quarterly planning notes"
Can you share what these are or how you go about making them?

Reply

Pingback: Deep Habits: The Importance of Planning Every Minute of Your Work Day | Working Scientist

Pingback: ?????????? | Meaning Ring

Rick

January 3, 2014 at 1:32 am

@LAURA

Make an Inventory sheet of what work you have to get done e.g. a list stating each activity.

Time-blocking then can planned a night before on certain tasks from your A4 inventory sheet of the activities you need to get done before a certain period. After each activity has been completed, just put a line through it on your inventory sheet.

note: this is not Cal's method but something that I personally use.

Reply

Pingback: Discover New Perspective – Time Blocking

Kumara S Raghavendra
January 7, 2014 at 12:41 pm

I'm quite meticulous in planning my day and have seen the benefits of it. But I don't always put it down on paper which sends me off track depending on my mood. This seems like the perfect cure for such days.

Reply

Kincaid Donovan
January 13, 2014 at 6:34 am

Well said. I was on the same dilemma prior to 'writing things down'. There just to be so many things out there and in as much as how you'd like to remember them all, some just slips off. Writing as proven itself to be a very good tool for keeping tabs of your daily tasks.

Reply

Kincaid Donovan
January 13, 2014 at 6:44 am

Well said. I was on the same dilemma prior to 'writing things down.' There just to be so many things out there that in as much as how we'd like to get them done, some just slips off. So yes, writing is really effective.

Reply

Pingback: A Productivity Hack That Will Help You Get More Done | CareerAdvisorDaily

Pingback: How you can make the most of your time | academicsuccessblog

Pingback: Simple Schedule | Get Real Journal

Pingback: 10-20 minutes spent time blocking the next day ensures progress is being made on the tasks that matter | THE PAPER TUNERTHE PAPER TUNER

Rachel

January 25, 2014 at 3:18 pm

I have a family member whose work requires he make space for walk ins and potential crises. He guarantees he will be in his office in the morning and that if he has out of office duties, he will take care of those in the afternoon. Because it is the only time they are guaranteed to find him, everyone comes in during the morning. This leaves the afternoon open for offsite duties and uninterrupted deep work. Very much fits with your idea of scheduling reactive time in blocks. This model has been successful for him going on 30 years!

Reply

Pingback: The Two Words That Will Lead You To Success And Happiness

Pingback: Increase Your Writing Productivity (part 3): the power of routine | Susan Dennard

Laura

February 25, 2014 at 9:39 pm

Cal, is there a reason you use hard bound books rather than electronic versions of your schedules and ideas?

Reply

Tjerk
February 26, 2014 at 12:29 pm

Cal,

I have a simple question: how and when do you deal with your co-authors?

As a graduate student I struggle a lot with the following paradox: on the one hand, I would like to immerse more into deep work; on the other hand, the more various co-authors of various papers (at various stages) constantly set my agenda. (The only solution I've been able to come up with is to work more as a single author, yet this reduces direct feedback)

When I look at your (academic) CV, I see all of your papers are co-authored by three, four or five. How and when do you deal with co-authors, while at the same time carving out such huge chunks of deep work?

Reply

Pingback: the other side of the coin | mummy lounge

Pingback: 3 Words for 2014

Pingback: Time Blocking Your Way to Success | Zero To CompleteZero To Complete

David K
April 8, 2014 at 12:45 pm

This is lovely. Would you make a blocking chart that includes a 3 year-old and a 1 year-old? Thanks!

Reply

Study Hacks
April 8, 2014 at 5:40 pm

As indicated by the title, time blocking applies to work time (i.e., time at an office). If you work with a 3-year old and a 1-year old you probably have a deeper problem to tackle first!

Reply

martin

February 15, 2015 at 8:51 am

I have a two and zero year old. I know what you mean. The only time blocking is planned activities e.g. swimming lesson and bed time I.e. shower, brush teeth then bed. Good luck!

Reply

Pingback: The Two Words That Will Lead You To Success and Happiness - TIME

Pingback: Get back to Your Life! 5 Apps that Protect Your Time | Rob Caraway

Pingback: You don't need productivity hacks: here's how to get things done.

Pingback: Thursday 140508 « Indianapolis CrossFit Affiliate – TitanFit

Pingback: Time Blocking | Buck Living

Pingback: 3 Reasons You Are Lying to Yourself When You Say You Don't Have Enough Time

Pingback: 3 Reasons You Are Lying To Yourself When You Say 'I Don't Have Enough Time'

Pingback: Deep Habits: The Importance of Planning Every Minute of Your Work Day | FIVE9341

Danny Sieg Reghart
June 3, 2014 at 5:18 pm

Awesome!! 😀

This tracking time way was probably the greatest thing we can start today, this will help us to improve ourself.. How we use our time relates closely to how we fuel our self-growth.. 🙂

Reply

Justin
June 3, 2014 at 6:33 pm

I think this article addresses an important yet under-appreciated problem faced by many people. Especially as it relates to health, time management and prioritization of important versus urgent

a fun, visual platform with which to design my day, called Owaves (www.owaves.com). Hope this is helpful a relevant audience.

Reply

Pingback: How to Do More Work in Less Time | The UP Lab

Pingback: Deep Habits: When the Going Gets Tough, Build a Temporary Plan - Study Hacks - Cal Newport

Andrew Voss

September 19, 2014 at 3:02 am

I am a teacher, and just recently started to use this method and the autopilot schedule for all the work I have to do when I am not teaching. What a difference this has made. I am having the most stress-free year since I began teaching 11 years ago.

It doesn't have to be perfect. As you practice it more and more, your estimation will improve. Of all of Cal's posts, this one and the autopilot schedule have made the most impact. Now that I am getting control of my time, I can get into the deeper work aspects of my career more consistently.

Thank you, Cal.

Reply

Pingback: Procrastination and Hyperbolic Discounting | An Idle Mind is the Devil's Workshop

Pingback: 10 great productivity tips to GTD - Effective Brain

Pingback: Scheduling Large and Small | Solvable by Radicals

Daniel

November 11, 2014 at 5:33 am

Time blocking was covered on Season 2 episode 3 of Dr WHO.The Doctor was in a bind he needed to save a parallel universe at same time, but of course how can he be in two places at the same time, time blocking. Yes, the obvious answer to a perplexing problem. Of course he only had one hour according to BBC regulations to sort things out, and sort them out he did, Hurray Dr WHO.

Reply

Pingback: Deep Habits: Obsess When Needed - Study Hacks - Cal Newport

Pingback: Deep Habits: Obsess When Wanted | Posts

Barbra Ann
November 22, 2014 at 3:03 pm

Can someone PLEASE tell me where I can find an Android app for Time Blocking, I have searched and searched, and all I keep finding is time-blocking apps for high school and college “students”. I am an adult and want to schedule my time in chunks or blocks, but the student app isn’t what I am looking for.
Thanks

Reply

Pingback: Plan Out Your Day Productively with the “Time Blocking” Method | Emelar IT Group

Pingback: Plan Out Your Day Productively with the “Time Blocking” Method * The New World

CREATIVE
December 7, 2014 at 2:21 am

This works!!! BUT, you have to be committed to avoid distractions and focus on ONE activity at a time.

I’ve actually added a 5 min break every 60 mins, and 15 mins every 2 hours.

As for me 40 hours of work has been turned into 20 hours of work by using this system.

FOCUS

Reply

Pur
March 18, 2017 at 5:58 am

For some tasks which I hate, I add 5 minutes break every 20....

Reply

Pingback: Does This Actually Work? - Kyle Dunning

Pingback: Plan Out Your Day Productively With The 'Time Blocking' Method | Lifehacker Australia

Brade

February 26, 2015 at 9:00 pm

Dang, this is the opposite of the way I prefer to do things. Such a rigid approach to life!

Reply

Pingback: Failing to Plan

Jeff

March 8, 2015 at 9:59 pm

https://geon.github.io/estimator might be useful for time blocking.

Reply

Pingback: To do List vs Events List | Jonell Alvi

Pingback: Bookmarks for April 10th | Chris's Digital Detritus

Pingback: How to do time blocking

Pingback: 7 Steps to convert your Desire into Money | boxextra

Pingback: Academy Inspire July | Wedding and Event Planning Courses - AAWEP

Pingback: Be in Control of Your Business Time | Maile Collmer

Pingback: How to do time blocking - Safari Blog

Pingback: Productivity Hack: Work More Efficiently by Batching Your Time - Career

Pingback: Deep Habits: Process Trumps Results for Daily Planning - Study Hacks - Cal Newport

Pingback: Deep Habits: Course of Trumps Outcomes for Day by day Planning | Posts

Pingback: Stop Psyching Yourself Out and Start Studying | Actuarial Angle

Pingback: How to make decisions, stick with them, and be productive | Denny's Blog

Pingback: Productivity Hack: Work More Efficiently by Batching Your Time

Pingback: How I Plan My Day « Parks Computing

Pingback: How to organize your day using time blocking | navigating and negotiating academic worlds

Pingback: Days “off” is a misnomer | Use Your Legs

Étienne

September 20, 2015 at 1:17 pm

This is a very interesting article. I found it simply through Google looking for ways other than time blocking. I've been struggling with that due to the fact that I often can't stick to my schedule.

Fortunately, all the comments here and what is described motivate me to keep going and try it again.

Thanks a lot!

Reply

Pingback: Is There No Map? - Red-Green-Code

Pingback: 5 Smart Strategies to Help You Succeed in Graduate School | My Devotional Thoughts

Pingback: Deep Habits: Three Recent Daily Plans - Study Hacks - Cal Newport

Pingback: Time Management Tips for Small Business Owners

Pingback: Deep Work: Rules for Focused Success in a Distracted World - Study Hacks - Cal Newport

Pingback: Productivity Hack: Work More Efficiently By Batching Your Time | MBTN - Movebacktonigeria

Pingback: 7 Reorganizational Strategies for Work and Life | The Black Wall Street

Alex

December 2, 2015 at 4:04 am

This seems to not work for me. For one, making a daily schedule is not a trivial task for me-I skimmed one of Cal's books and he said it takes five minutes, but it might easily take me longer to think of everything I need to do in a day, and decide how much time I need to allocate. It is not always obvious how difficult each task is or what the priority of each task should be.

More importantly, I just don't do what's on my schedule. At all. Maybe I have ADD. (I was definitely diagnosed with ADD as a child.) What I've found to work so far is just writing down a list of tasks in order of priority. I then go down the list until I'm done with each task. I don't try to predict how much time I will need for each task. Maybe my problem is that when I try to switch tasks I am very prone to distractions and spending huge amounts of time surfing the web or whatever, so I need to focus on one task for a long time and totally block out distractions to get anywhere.

In the future I may try out bringing some elements of "time blocking" into my daily routine-maybe I will have a few fixed tasks throughout the day. But trying to schedule my entire day has not worked.

and causation. The folks with great focus, executive function and planning ability do time blocking and get stuff done. This is not because time blocking is that great for getting stuff done for everyone. It's because it's good for folks who are focused enough to stick to their schedule and they also have an easier time doing it.

Is there any published research or study that supports this method of planning as practical?

Reply

Toby

May 27, 2017 at 9:09 pm

Alex, I too find standard motivational and productivity techniques don't work for me.
I've often wondered why, and felt guilt, believing it was lack of effort on my part.
Therefore I appreciate your insight that they work well for people who have the skill and ability to use them, but they don't give you the skill or ability.
I have ADHD-like symptoms and mild autism, and I've yet to find a technique that compensates for my lack of focus and planning ability and allows me to prosper.
If you've found anything helpful, please do let me know.

Reply

Pingback: Year End Tips: 7 Ways to Reorganize Yourself

Pingback: 7 Ways to Reorganize Yourself During the Busiest Time of the Year - Euspert

Pingback: 7 Ways to Reorganize Yourself During the Busiest Time of the Year | Baytek Blog | Baytek Blog

Pingback: Three Life Hacks For Increased Home Business Productivity - April O'Leary

Pingback: Deep Work: Schedules | Solvable by Radicals

Pingback: Deep Work – Book Review – Emergence

Andrew

January 27, 2016 at 12:07 am

Dear Cal,
I use this process extensively (well, at least I try to) after being introduced to it by a friend back in early 2015. How do you deal with asynchronous tasks? I have lots of work that is very important (that I want to send out ASAP so coworkers can work on it) that depends on stuff like pulling data, running a model, etc. that comes back after awhile, but leaves big gaps to work on other stuff (I am a data scientist/software engineer). Would be great to hear your thoughts/thoughts of other smart people who read this blog.

Reply

Pingback: What's in my backpack? - Will Schoeffler

Pingback: Weekly Digest – 2/14 – Evolvican

Pingback: Narrative My personal story of Productivity - Narrative

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Dulce Gomez
March 30, 2016 at 4:27 am

This method you use is very interesting and a very helpful way to organize your time, I will give it a try! I am starting out with my own blog and I was wondering if you had any advice or tips on

Reply

Vicki Leoni
April 12, 2016 at 10:03 pm

Dulce!

You've discovered a fantastic blog post! Great information!

I hope you share with your fellow AVID students. 🙂

Reply

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Pingback: Stop Being Distracted: 7 Powerful Tools to Help You Stay Focused on Your Business Goals - The Entrepreneur Campfire

Pingback: 10 Time-Saving Tips for Optimal Performance - Domainate

Andrew
September 19, 2016 at 11:55 pm

Nico's post (response #2 on the first comment) about the content not being strictly defined was super super helpful for me.

Reply

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Pingback: Block Scheduling: What It Is & Will It Work For You - Time for Planning

Pingback: Productivity Series: Take Control of Your Calendar - Branding Outside The Box

Maile Allison

April 13, 2017 at 2:26 am

Time blocking is something that I need to start integrating into my school week. Planning specific times when I need to study and work on assignments would improve my school performance. I could also add my work schedule and block out times in the day to workout. I would then be able to appreciate the time that I have off during the day. Rather than procrastinating my work and telling myself over and over that I will do it later. Very interesting post! I'll start time-blocking this week and see how it changes my work performance.

Reply

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Pingback: The Deep Work of Writing, part 3 of 3 » Lisa Rivero

Pingback: Deep Habits: The Importance of Planning Every Minute of Your Work Day – Momentum Leadership in Action Programme

Pingback: Adventures in Time Blocking – Army Of Minions

Matic
June 21, 2017 at 7:38 pm

I can agree with the post so much that we even made a tool to

Reply

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Pingback: Deep Work in Practice - Applying Cal's Concepts - Jeremey DuVall

Pingback: Time Tortoise: Future Plans - Red-Green-Code

AML

January 2, 2018 at 9:06 pm

Discipline equals freedom.

Reply

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Pingback: Grammar Lessons – Project Lingual

Jason

October 30, 2018 at 4:17 am

Terrific system for a lawyer. I'm a Canadian courtroom lawyer with a very busy practice, and for the past 10 years, I have constantly found myself being pressed for time for trial prep.

I started time blocking a couple weeks ago, following your method, adjusting my schedule daily, as necessary. It was difficult at first, but I stuck with it. I am amazed at how much more I now get done, directly as a result of your method. I can get as much done in a 60 hour week as I could in 90 hours without detailed planning, and to a higher standard. I can't tell you how much of a difference this is making in my personal and professional life. Wish I'd known

Reply

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Pingback: S?u t?m – 10 In-Depth Strategies to Improve Your Focus and Produce High-Quality Work – Nguyen Phi Long

Pingback: Time Blocking, Part 3: 6 Tips | J. David Stark

Harley Eades
July 17, 2019 at 3:23 pm

I'm a professor as well whose research is getting more complex to manage. One question I had is how do you setup your weekly and quarterly plans? Any advice on that?

Reply

Shaun

August 8, 2019 at 10:36 am

This is one of those one-page wonders; thank you for sharing this essential skill and method – it's very much appreciated Cal!

People often over-egg the pudding for productivity, looking for that deep, complex, step-to-step guide to solving their productivity challenges, when all it really needs is something simple they can do NOW.

Reply

Frank Davis

September 23, 2019 at 6:17 pm

To have an effective team means to provide it with the best timetracker. I am sure that every entrepreneur knows how hard it can be without timetracker especially when his team is rather big, I have been using https://tmetric.com/ tracker for my team and strongly believe it is the best variant for it.

Reply

Jon

October 10, 2019 at 9:03 am

Cal, do you apply the same process of planning and time blocking to your personal time?

Reply

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Pingback: How To Make A Weekly Planner In Notion - Excel Me

Pingback: Indecision Leads to Inaction. – Edward White

Tricia

October 19, 2022 at 12:48 pm

Oh, wow, really, every minute? It sounds like a lot of planning! I agree that planning is important, but maybe not in such detail. Anyway, if you want to know some good ways to plan your day more efficiently, here's something that might help: https://

steps

Reply

Yogesh Shinde
March 21, 2024 at 3:21 am

Hey Cal,

Your book helped me in my work and personal life.

I recently realized the world runs on time blocking.

For example, we have our school timing scheduled and election dates are scheduled and why? because it works.

That's it.

When we block our time we are obligated to do that particular task and it makes our (everyone) life simple. Simplicity is hardest thing to achieve.

Thanks again for the informative blog.

Reply

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Post Comment



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Cal launched the "Study Hacks" blog at calnewport.com in 2007, and has been regularly publishing essays here ever since. Over 2,000,000 people a year visit this site to read Cal's weekly posts about technology, productivity, and the quest to live

subscribe to have these essays delivered directly to their inbox (see the sign-up form below). To read more, you can browse more than 15 years of past essays in the archive.

In the fall of 2022, Cal launched a new portal, TheDeepLife.com, to serve as the online home for all other content relevant to the deep life movement he helped initiate. Here you can find all past episodes of Cal's popular podcast, *Deep Questions*, and explore an extensive library of original videos.

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